

BPSC General Studies Special: Bihar History, Art & Geography

Chapter 1: Ancient Bihar

Ancient Bihar: Magadha Empire & Buddhist Renaissance

Ancient Bihar was the cradle of great spiritual and political revolutions. Magadha rose as the pre-eminent Mahajanapada under the Haryanka dynasty (Bimbisara founded Rajgir/Girivraja, Ajatashatru built Pataliputra fort and convened the First Buddhist Council at Rajgir in 483 BC).

Under the Mauryas, Chandragupta Maurya and Emperor Ashoka established Pan-Indian administration with capital at Pataliputra. Ashoka's edicts (Lauriya Nandangarh, Rampurva, Sasaram) reveal Dhamma administration.

Nalanda Mahavihara was founded by Gupta ruler Kumaragupta I, attracting Xuanzang (Hiuen Tsang) and I-Tsing, before being pillaged by Bakhtiyar Khilji in 1193 AD.

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Chapter 2: Bihar Freedom Movement

Bihar in the 1857 Revolt & Freedom Struggle

The 1857 uprising in Bihar was heralded by the Patna rebellion led by bookseller Pir Ali Khan on July 3, 1857, who was executed by Commissioner William Tayler.

Babu Veer Kunwar Singh, the 80-year-old Zamindar of Jagdishpur (Arrah), led a heroic guerrilla campaign across Bihar and Eastern UP (Azamgarh), defeating British forces under Captain Le Grand before his martyrdom in April 1858.

Champaran Satyagraha (1917) was Gandhi's first civil disobedience experiment in India, launched on the persistent invitation of Raj Kumar Shukla against European planters enforcing the Tinkathia system (compulsory indigo planting on 3/20th of land). Associated leaders included Dr. Rajendra Prasad, J.B. Kripalani, and Anugrah Narayan Sinha.

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Chapter 3: Bihar Geography

Physical Geography & Drainage of Bihar

Bihar covers 94,163 sq km, located in the middle Ganga plain. It is physiographically divided into: 1. Shiwalik foothills (Someswar range in West Champaran); 2. Bihar Plain (divided by the Ganges into North Bihar Plain and South Bihar Plain); 3. Southern Plateau margin (Kaimur plateau and Chotanagpur fringe).

The Ganges flows west to east for ~445 km through 12 districts in Bihar. Left-bank Himalayan tributaries (Ghaghara, Gandak, Burhi Gandak, Bagmati, Kamla-Balan, Kosi - Sorrow of Bihar) cause chronic annual inundations.

Right-bank peninsular tributaries include the Karmanasa, Son (originates at Amarkantak, irrigates Rohtas canal system), Punpun, and Falgu (sacred river at Gaya).